

I - Interviewer

S - Speaker

I: Good day. Thank you again for participating in this interview.

I: As I mentioned in the message I sent, I want to learn more about your thoughts on romantic relationships.

I: I believe your experiences and perspective will greatly contribute to the project.

I: Before we start, would it be okay for me to record this interview?

I: I will only use this recording for transcription purposes.

S: That's fine.

I: Thank you.

I: First, how old are you?

S: I am [26-30] years old.

I: How long have you been with your partner?

S: Over [1-5] years.

I: Do you have any children?

S: No.

I: Okay.

I: Can you tell me who you live with at home?

S: Sure. I live with my family.

I: Hmm-hmm.

I: What is your main source of income?

S: Currently, I work at a [company]. I work at a company.

I: How would you like me to refer to your partner? Spouse, friend, lover? How should I proceed?

S: You can say lover.

I: Okay.

I: Can you tell me the story of how you met and how your relationship started?

S: Sure, we met at [location].

I: Can you raise your voice a bit?

S: Of course.. Is it better now?

I: Hmm-hmm.

S: We met at [location], then we became friends and continued our relationship this way.

I: When did you meet, how did it develop, can you elaborate a bit more?

S: Sure.. When did we meet.. uh.. it was school time, we were going to school, we were students. We flirted for a short time and then we decided to become lovers. We continued this way.

I: Compared to your friends' relationships, how do you evaluate the quality of your own relationship?

S: Well, we like to understand and listen to each other. We enjoy chatting. We value spending time together. Actually, what we see outside, some friends don't want to value or spend time. We value each other, we like spending time together, that's it.

I: Can you elaborate on why you think this way?

S: Sure. Because from what I see with my friends, I think it's wrong not to chat, not to spend time, not to value, not to show understanding. I think these are valuable.

I: Can I ask how many romantic relationships you've had in the past?

S: In the past, I actually didn't have a serious and romantic relationship to this extent.

I: So how many loves have you had?

S: How many loves.. [1-5] or [1-5] I can say. But they were short-term, not as long as this.

I: Compared to your previous relationships, how do you evaluate the quality of your current relationship?

S: Well, now I can express myself and understand the other party more comfortably. Valuing and giving importance is more in this relationship, and that makes me happy. I can say it this way.

I: Why do you say that?

I: I want to elaborate a bit, that's why I'm asking. Can you elaborate on why you said that?

S: Sure.. You feel it. For example, on special days, more importance is given. Value is given, time can be allocated. These are very valuable in this relationship.

I: What makes a relationship high quality for you? What makes it qualified?

S: What makes it qualified is actually high quality, understanding, tolerance, respect.. these actually.

I: What makes it low quality?

S: The exact opposite of these, not showing understanding, not being respectful, the absence of respect sometimes, not being able to communicate. These can be.

I: Again, if I ask why you think this way?

S: Sure, because if there's no communication, a healthy relationship won't happen. If there's no understanding, similarly, a healthy relationship won't happen. Tolerance is also included in this.

I: So, if I say, I: a relationship in which you can communicate, a respectful relationship, a strong relationship, in other words, a high-quality relationship, can you say that?

S: Yes, I can.

I: So, can you give me more information about how a person knows they are in an understanding relationship? How does one realize this?

S: Sure, things that happen during the day, I mean, things that happen in our daily lives, can be examples of this, like, how can I give an example? I'm thinking about that. Uh, what could it be? For example, that day, something important, urgent came up. We planned for today, we were going to meet. Something important came up, we couldn't meet. It was very urgent. Here, for example, not showing a reaction, showing understanding, shows that the person is understanding.

I: So, when can you say your partner is understanding?

S: Yes, most of the time I can say that. I mean, actually, being understanding in bad situations, in negative times, in times when you don't feel good, the other party is understanding, these are important, I mean, it's felt in these times.

I: So, at least, when was it the least understanding, in your opinion?

S: The least, when was it understanding... Can you repeat the question?

I: At least, when was it the least understanding?

I: Or, for example, you said, high-quality means understanding, communication, respect. At least, when these are the least, I'm asking.

S: When it is the least, of course, no one is perfect. Sometimes there may be situations where we don't understand each other, these are already minimized. When communication cannot be established, actually lack of communication is the reason for this.

I: Hmm-hmm. Is there anything you can give as an example that comes to your mind, in your daily life?

S: Sure, for example, if there is a problem, if it cannot be discussed, it affects negatively. It takes away understanding, tolerance. It takes away communication. The most important thing is when communication breaks down you cannot solve things. This lowers the quality, inevitably.

I: So, what are the most important things in a relationship for you?

S: As I said, respect, tolerance, understanding, communication. These are important to me.

I: Can you elaborate on these? Why do you think this way?

S: Sure, as I mentioned in the questions, these are things I can base the quality on. The most important is communication, if there is no communication, most things are already affected. So we can frame the others around putting communication at the center. Understanding, respect, tolerance, these.

I: So, for you. In your opinion. What is love (aşk)?

S: What is love (aşk)? living together living a life together, thinking it will continue, like being able to get along with each other, sharing things together. Not being able to do anything without them or most of the time matching everything with them. We can say this.

I: So, in a relationship, how important do you think love (aşk) is? It's as important as communication. Hmm-hmm

S: This is my only and short answer, I think.

I: So, how do you understand that your lover loves (sevmek) you?

S: First, of course, does she communicate with me I look at that. If we can communicate and if she values me and acts tolerantly this already stems from love (sevgi). If there is no love (sevgi), these wouldn't be there. This way.

I: So, what would you say are the challenges in your relationship?

S: I can tell you the challenges in my relationship. Actually, I hadn't thought about it.

I: Hmm-hmm you can think, we have time.

S: Sure. Since people always think about good things, they don't bring bad things to mind. I mean, not being able to communicate sometimes, even if rarely, not being able to communicate is a bad thing. Not being able to solve the problem, prolonging the problem or not being able to communicate at that moment such things may happen.

I: So, if we elaborate a bit more, do you and your partner argue?

S: Well, inevitably. I mean, things that happen in daily life, this not a fight, but it can generally be in the form of a discussion. Because there, both people are trying to explain themselves after all.

I: Hmm-hmm.

S: There are intersecting points inevitably. Like.

I: So, these fights, yes, I'm listening.

S: Intersecting points can happen. This I think it should be solved by discussing or in a normal way.

I: Can you say how often these fights, discussions happen?

S: How often. Well, this can change depending on the level of the discussion. I mean, if it's a normal, sweet discussion it can be once in [1-5] weeks, in [1-5] weeks even. Such very intense discussions. Maybe once every [1-5] months it happens.

I: So, these fights, discussions what are they usually about?

S: Well, not being able to agree at that moment I don't know, not being able to communicate if there is a request, maybe not being able to fulfill it.

I: Can you give an example? I mean, generally what do you argue about?

S: Can I give an example? I'm thinking right now can I give an example? Well, if she wanted something at that moment. Like can we do this? Maybe I might have forgotten. It might be very important. It could have been forgotten. This can be an example of any argument or as I said, a request not being met expectation, not meeting the expectation it can be this way.

I: So how do you solve these fights, discussions?

S: By communicating, talking showing understanding. At least: by talking in some way.

I: Apart from these what are other ways to maintain your relationship in your opinion? Apart from the solutions you suggested?

S: Well other solutions didn't happen at all. I mean, by communicating talking we solved most things.

I: Hmm-hmm

S: This way.

I: So, can you say that this relationship is good for you?

S: Yes, I can say that.

I: If I ask why? You can give concrete examples from your daily life.

S: Sure, like spending time together, understanding, respect, love (sevgi), love (aşk) is the most important factor; it indeed holds a significant place in a relationship. In our relationship, I mean. In this way, that is.

I: Has this relationship changed you?

S: Yes.

I: In what way did it change you? Can you elaborate?

S: Sure, I mean, the other party there are mutual expectations. Within the framework of these expectations, somehow, change can happen. I changed to make the other party happy in that sense.

I: Has your partner changed during this relationship?

S: Yes, she has changed. She has changed too.

I: Let me put it this way. For example, is the person you were before the relationship the same as the person you are now?

S: No, definitely not.

I: In what way? Or why?

S: Well, why, let's see. I used to be a person who liked to spend more time outside. Now, I enjoy spending time with him. I don't go out with my friends as often as I used to. Besides that, I can change based on his expectations. I value special days, for example. I didn't value them before, in this way.

I: So, is your partner the same as before the relationship?

S: No.

I: How has she changed? Or why do you think she changed?

S: Well, she used to say she was more irritable, but now she is calmer. She can handle most things more calmly. Of course, some of this comes with age. As you get older, some things settle more easily and are understood more easily. In this way.

I: Do you feel safe in this relationship?

S: Yes, I feel safe.

I: Can you elaborate on why you say that?

S: Sure, because I can communicate easily.

I: Hmm-hmm

S: I can feel peaceful.

I: Can you give concrete examples of these? Moments when you feel peaceful and safe.

S: I feel

I: Hmm-hmm

S: Safe, like, with my lover, I can talk about what I want in the way I want without hesitation. In that way. That's why I feel safe.

I: Now I'm going to show you a scale. Can you see it? Is it clear?

S: Yes.

I: If I ask, "My partner generally really listens to me." On a scale from one to nine, one being not true at all, nine being completely true. What would you choose?

S: My partner generally really listens to me. I would say eight.

I: Hmm-hmm. You chose eight. If I ask why not nine or seven?

S: Sure. Now, nine, for me, is something impossible for anyone. Because we are all human. No one is perfect. Every day is not the same. We are not robots after all. That's why. Seven, on the other hand, because she listens to me, I gave it eight. Seven is actually, She really listens to me. That's why I didn't want to give seven. I gave eight.

I: Okay. If I ask, "My partner is generally sensitive to my needs." Again, on a scale from one to nine, one not true at all, nine completely true. "My partner is generally sensitive to my needs."

S: My partner is generally sensitive to my needs. (Repeats 3 times.) Well, in terms of sensitivity, because she values me, as I said, I will say eight again.

I: Hmm-hmm

S: Well, I will say the same thing. Actually, nine should be something extraordinary, perfect. This is something impossible. She is already sensitive to me. That's why I say eight.

I: You also rated "My partner really listens to me" as eight. Can you give concrete examples of when these happen in your daily life?

S: Sure. The most important thing is that in our daily life, how can I say, in our daily experiences, we can easily share everything with each other every evening. And we talked last evening. We also talk during the day, but we had this talk last night, She really listened to me.

I: Hmm-hmm

S: Well, If I ask for examples of when your partner is sensitive to your needs, you gave the answer eight. Can you give examples of when this happens? When they were sensitive to your needs.

S: Well, needs, for example? Well, at that moment I wanted them by my side, because we went to a hospital for a relative of mine, and she didn't leave me alone. At that moment, I needed him. Well, she was by my side, She was sensitive in this matter.

I: Okay. I hope you don't mind me asking. If this is too sensitive for you to share, please feel free to say so. But I want to learn more about your physical intimacy as a couple. How often do you have sexual relations these days?

S: I can say never.

I: Hmm-hmm. It could be sexual relations or physical closeness.

S: Well, for example, we like touching each other. We like hugging. These are enough for us at the moment.

I: Well, if I ask how satisfied you are with your sexual life,

S: Well, I'm satisfied right now, I don't have any complaints. At least.

I: Why do you think so?

S: I mean, because we are not married. As a result, that's why I'm satisfied.

I: So, if I ask how satisfied you are with your relationship overall, I will show you a scale. Can you see it? Completely dissatisfied. Not very satisfied. Somewhat dissatisfied. Not sure.

Indecisive. Somewhat satisfied. Very satisfied. Completely satisfied.

S: Completely satisfied.

I: Hmm-hmm

S: Will you ask why?

I: No, I was curious about the numerical value since you said completely satisfied. Again, on a scale from zero to ten, zero being not satisfied at all, ten being completely satisfied. What number would you say?

S: I would say nine again. As with the others.

I: Why not ten or eight, if I ask?

S: Well, satisfaction, I mean, I am really very satisfied.

I: Hmm-hmm.

S: Eight would be too low for me. Ten, as I said, is such an impossible point, I gave nine as the closest value.

I: Has your relationship met your expectations?

S: Yes, it has.

I: In what way, for example?

S: In what way, well, because we already shared our expectations with each other, we could evolve in that direction. You asked if we changed.

I: Hmm-hmm

S: We both changed in line with these expectations. And we continue to change.

I: Well, we are about to finish. I want to summarize what we talked about in the last half hour. You generally said that the most important thing for you is communication. You mentioned that you can solve discussions by communicating. You said you are currently satisfied with your sexual life, even though there is no sexual relationship.

S: Hmm-hmm.

I: You said you have been in a relationship for [1-5] years. You said that you can both change for the relationship, and you continue to do so. Were these correct, do you have anything else to add?

S: No, they were correct.

I: Do you have anything else to add?

S: No, I don't, but if you have another question, I can answer it.

I: No, my questions are over. Thank you very much for participating.

S: Thank you.

I: Before finishing, I want to talk to you about how I will handle the data. I want to be as transparent as possible from an ethical standpoint. So I would like to know which data sharing option is most suitable for you. I will now read two options to you. You can choose whichever is suitable for you. The first option is to share some sections of our interview transcript. None of these sections will contain any information that can identify you. This way, the anonymized interview transcript can be read by other researchers.

S: Hmm-hmm

I: The second option is, if you don't mind and want to be a bit more bold, to share the entire interview transcript after removing sensitive and highly identifying details, making it anonymous. In this option, there is a slight chance that someone who knows you well could piece together the details and narrow down who you are among your colleagues. Again, I want to emphasize that no sensitive information will be shared. Which of the two options would you prefer?

S: Of course, you can use all my options with peace of mind. As long as it is anonymous. Other than that.

I: Thank you for participating in this study.

S: I wish you continued success.

I: I want you to know that this study is also being conducted in the Philippines, Brazil, the Netherlands, France, and the United States. For this study to be successful, if it's convenient for you, I have one more request.

S: Sure.

I: Can you suggest two close people from your life as candidates? And I will ask them to suggest other couples who might be interested in this study. I won't interview the people you suggest. I will ask them to suggest people you don't know, like neighbors, work colleagues, etc. This way, I can reach as diverse participants as possible. Is this suitable for you? If it's suitable, can you give me their contact number so it won't appear on the recording?

S: Sure, let me also talk to my girlfriend. If we find a suitable person, they will already contact you. I am a bit busy with work, she will contact you in this regard. Is that okay?

I: Okay. Thank you again for participating. I am stopping the recording now.

S: Sure.